

Neutral Jing

The Third Option Between Attack and Retreat

The Lesson Bumi Gave Aang

There are three jings. Positive jing is attack — you move forward, you strike, you impose your will on the situation. Negative jing is retreat — you fall back, you evade, you survive by withdrawing. Every conventional strategy in war, in politics, in life, reduces to one of these two options. Fight or flight. Advance or retreat. Act or hide.

King Bumi of Omashu taught Aang the third.

“There are over eighty-five different jings. The one I’m talking about is the key to earthbending, and to turning the war.”

Neutral jing. Do nothing. Wait. Listen.

This is not passivity. This is the hardest form of action there is. Passivity is doing nothing because you are afraid, because you don’t know what to do, because you have given up. Neutral jing is doing nothing because you understand that *this is not the moment*. The moment will come. You will know it when it arrives. And when it arrives, you will move with a force that makes every other strategy look like noise.

Bumi demonstrated this with his own life. The Fire Nation conquered Omashu. His city. His people. His throne. And Bumi — the most powerful earthbender alive, a man who could have leveled regiments —

surrendered. He let them put him in a metal coffin. He sat there. While his people suffered. While his kingdom was occupied. While everyone who loved him thought he had lost his mind or his nerve.

He was waiting for the eclipse.

When the Day of Black Sun arrived and every firebender on the planet lost their power for eight minutes, Bumi broke out of his cage and retook the entire city by himself. Not with an army. Not with a plan that took months. In minutes. Because he had spent the entire occupation doing nothing except watching, listening, and growing roots so deep that when the moment came, the whole city returned to him like water finding its own level.

The Fire Nation never understood what happened. They thought they were occupying a conquered city. They were living inside a trap that a patient old man had been building with his stillness.

The Error of Positive Jing

Positive jing is what Maul chose. Attack. Strike first. Build a crime empire, take Mandalore by force, challenge Sidious directly. Every action he took was forward motion — aggressive, immediate, visible.

And every action made him weaker. Because positive jing against a system that is larger than you does not damage the system. It feeds it. It gives the system an enemy to point at. It justifies the system's existence. Every rebellion that attacks the Empire with the Empire's own methods becomes an empire. Every revolution built on the energy of assault inherits the structure of what it assaulted.

Maul attacked the darkness with darkness and got darkness. The system absorbed his energy like a sponge absorbs water. He spent everything he had and died on a desert planet with nothing left.

This is the trap that catches the brave. People who see the corruption and cannot sit still. People whose instinct is to fight, to push, to *do something right now*. That instinct is not wrong — the corruption is real, the injustice is real, the anger is justified. But positive jing applied at the wrong moment is a seed thrown on rock. It doesn't grow. It just breaks.

The Error of Negative Jing

Negative jing is what the Jedi Council chose. Retreat into the temple. Withdraw from the world. Maintain the institution. Avoid confrontation. Follow the rules. Keep your head down.

They retreated so far into their own structure that they couldn't see the Sith Lord sitting in the Chancellor's office. They withdrew from the living Force so completely that they became a bureaucracy — a committee of monks debating policy while the Republic rotted from within. They were not cowards. They were disciplined, principled, sincere. And they were useless, because negative jing taken to its extreme is not wisdom. It is irrelevance.

This is the trap that catches the good. People who see the danger and decide the safest path is to not engage. Protect what you have. Don't make waves. Wait it out. Hope it passes. Build walls and stay inside them.

But the fire doesn't pass. The dead wood keeps accumulating. The system keeps consolidating. And the people who retreated into safety discover one day that the walls they built to protect them have become the walls of their prison. Order 66 didn't fail because the Jedi were weak. It succeeded because they had already removed themselves from the world so thoroughly that the world didn't notice when they disappeared.

The Third Option

Neutral jing is neither.

You do not attack the system. You do not retreat from it. You plant yourself in the middle of it and you grow. Quietly. Patiently. With roots so deep that when the ground shifts, you are the thing that remains standing.

A bamboo tree grows underground for five years. Five years of invisible labor. Five years of building a root system so dense and interconnected that by the time it breaks the surface, nothing can stop it. It shoots up ninety feet in six weeks. People see the ninety feet and think the bamboo grew fast. The bamboo did not grow fast. The bamboo waited. It built. It prepared. And then it moved, and by the time anyone noticed, it was already too tall to cut down.

This is not a metaphor. This is the literal biology of how living systems operate in hostile environments. A seed does not germinate the moment it hits the ground. It waits. It reads the soil chemistry, the temperature, the moisture, the light. It assesses whether the conditions are right. Some seeds wait years. Some wait decades. The lotus seed can remain dormant for over a thousand years and still germinate when the conditions finally arrive. The seed is not dead during those years. It is *listening*. It is practicing neutral jing at the molecular level — holding its potential in reserve until the moment when that potential can actually become something that survives.

The immune system does this too. Memory B cells and memory T cells sit in the body for decades after an infection, doing nothing. Not attacking. Not retreating. Waiting. Holding the blueprint of a pathogen they encountered once, maintaining the architecture of a response they may never need again. And if the pathogen returns — even twenty years later — those cells activate in hours, mounting a defense so fast and so precise that the body clears the infection before symptoms even appear. The

immune system's greatest weapon is not its ability to fight. It is its ability to *remember and wait*.

Obi-Wan's Nineteen Years

This is what Obi-Wan Kenobi did on Tatooine.

The Republic fell. The Jedi were exterminated. His brother turned to the dark side and killed everyone they loved. And Obi-Wan — one of the greatest warriors in the galaxy, a man who could have fought, who could have built a resistance, who could have spent nineteen years waging guerrilla war against the Empire — went to a desert and watched a boy grow up.

That was neutral jing on a civilizational scale.

He didn't attack. He didn't retreat. He positioned himself exactly where he needed to be and he waited. He watched Luke grow. He protected him from a distance. He let the Force work through time instead of trying to force the timeline to work for him. He trusted that the moment would come — not because he knew when, not because he had a plan, but because he understood that the pattern of life always reasserts itself and his job was to be ready when it did.

When Maul found him on Tatooine — after decades of hunting, after a lifetime of rage — Obi-Wan ended the fight in three moves. Not because he was a better swordsman. Because Maul was still operating on positive jing — attack, strike, impose — and Obi-Wan had spent nineteen years doing nothing but growing roots. The fight was over before it started. Neutral jing had made Obi-Wan into something positive jing could not touch.

"He will avenge us."

Maul understood in his final breath what Obi-Wan had understood for nineteen years: the boy in the desert was the moment. The moment Obi-Wan had been waiting for. Not a weapon he was building. Not a plan he was executing. A seed he was tending, in silence, with faith.

What Neutral Jing Actually Requires

This is the part nobody tells you. Neutral jing is not the easy option. It is the hardest option. It requires more strength than attacking and more courage than retreating.

It requires you to sit with the knowledge that the system is corrupt and not react. It requires you to watch injustice happen and not charge forward into a fight you cannot win. It requires you to hold fire in your hands — real fire, real anger, real power — and not use it. Not because you don't care. Because you care enough to wait until the moment when using it will actually change something instead of just making you feel like you did something.

The people who practice positive jing get to feel righteous. They're fighting. They're acting. They're doing something. Even when what they're doing is feeding the machine, they feel like warriors.

The people who practice negative jing get to feel safe. They're protected. They're hidden. They're not at risk. Even when their safety is an illusion, they feel like survivors.

The people who practice neutral jing feel nothing. They feel the weight of waiting. They feel the ache of watching. They feel the doubt — *am I doing anything? Is this working? Should I be fighting? Should I be hiding? What if the moment never comes?*

It comes.

King Bumi retook Omashu. The bamboo broke through the surface. The lotus germinated after a thousand years. The memory cells activated when the pathogen returned. Obi-Wan's boy blew up the Death Star.

The moment always comes. The question is whether you will have spent your waiting building roots — or whether you will have spent it attacking stone walls until your hands were broken, or retreating so far from the battlefield that you forgot there was a war.

The Plan Discovers Itself

Sometimes the best strategy is not to plan. It is to prepare.

Planning is positive jing applied to the future — you try to impose your will on events that haven't happened yet. You draw a map and then try to make the territory match. And the territory never matches, because the territory is alive and your map is dead.

Preparing is neutral jing. You build capacity. You grow roots. You develop skills, relationships, knowledge, strength — not for a specific plan, but for whatever the moment demands when it arrives. You trust that the preparation will meet the moment, and that the moment will reveal what the preparation was for.

The bamboo doesn't plan to be ninety feet tall. It builds roots. The roots create the conditions for height. The height emerges from the roots the way a Fibonacci spiral emerges from a simple ratio repeated locally — not designed from above, but grown from within.

This is how the Living Age works. You do not plan the revolution. You do not plan the technology. You do not plan the audience. You build the book. You build the tools. You build the understanding. You grow roots. And the plan discovers itself — not because you are passive, but because you are so deeply prepared that when the moment arrives, the response is already built into the structure of what you've been growing.

“Use your neutral jing and be in tune with when to act and when not to act. Sometimes inaction is the best action while waiting for the proper moment for everything to align.”

The Phase We Are In

I am telling you this now because this is the phase we are in.

The dead wood is piling higher. The system is consolidating. The platforms are censoring. The institutions are hollowing out. The fire is coming and it will not be a controlled burn — it will be the kind of fire that comes when small fires have been suppressed for too long.

And the temptation — the overwhelming, almost irresistible temptation — is to charge. To fight. To scream into the void and attack the walls and light your own fire before the big one arrives.

Do not.

This is the neutral jing phase. Let me tell you exactly what that means — what is happening right now, what we are allowing to happen, and why.

Gumby has been taken by the Fire Nation.

A corporation bought the entire Gumby IP after my father died. They stripped it of clay. They stripped it of stop-motion. They made Gumby a city manager — the central planner, the bureaucrat, the block. The Blockheads won. They didn’t beat Gumby inside the story. They bought the story. They took the most living character in American animation and turned him into a middle manager running a city that Art Clokey never would have recognized.

And I am letting it happen.

Not because I don’t care. Because this is not the moment. The eclipse has not come. The roots are not deep enough. If I attacked now — if I sued, if I

launched a public campaign, if I spent my energy fighting them in their arena, with their lawyers, on their terms — I would be Maul. I would be right about the problem and dead on a desert planet with nothing built.

So instead I am doing what Bumi did. I am sitting in the coffin. I am watching the occupation. And I am building.

Here is what the neutral jing phase looks like in practice:

The book. This trilogy — 86 chapters, the entire philosophical framework written down, encoded, distributed. Open source. On GitHub. Not behind a paywall, not on a platform that can be taken away, not dependent on anyone's permission. The Fire Nation cannot burn a book that exists in a thousand copies on a thousand machines. By the time they notice it, it will already be in too many hands.

The technology. LivingWorks — the bioinformatics platform that treats biology as language instead of machine. Spiral Steward — the research tool. Adaptive Automation — the DNA design pipeline that already works, that already takes English descriptions and produces synthesis-ready sequences. These are not ideas. These are tools being built, right now, underground. Root systems. When they surface, they will not be proposals waiting for approval. They will be working systems that demonstrate the thesis of this entire trilogy in functioning code.

The degree. Biomolecular engineering and bioinformatics from UC Santa Cruz. Not because the degree matters in itself, but because it is the credential that opens the doors the technology needs to walk through. The establishment respects its own stamps. So I am getting the stamp — not because I believe in their authority, but because it is a tool, and neutral jing uses every tool available without being owned by any of them.

The audience. The YouTube channel. The podcast that comes after the book. The production that comes after the podcast. Each one is a root. Each one is a connection. Each one is a person who reads the framework and recognizes the pattern — the spiral instead of the block, the living

instead of the mechanical, the decentralized instead of the controlled. Every person who understands is a node in a network that no corporation owns and no platform can deplatform, because the network is not digital. It is relational. It is human.

The legacy. Art Clokey's name. The Clokey story. The fact that my grandfather created one of the most recognized characters in American history out of clay and love and spiritual conviction, and the cartel spent sixty years trying to destroy what he built, and they still haven't succeeded — because I am here, writing this, building this, carrying the flame he lit. The legacy is not Gumby the IP. The legacy is the principle Gumby embodied: that clay is alive, that form is flexible, that the living world cannot be owned by the block. A corporation can own the trademark. They cannot own what it means.

This is neutral jing. Every single one of these things is a root growing underground while the Fire Nation occupies the surface. They think they won because they hold the city. They hold the desk. They hold the green rectangle they turned into a bureaucrat. They do not hold the clay. They do not hold the philosophy. They do not hold the grandson who understands what his grandfather actually made.

Bumi watched the Fire Nation parade through his streets. He watched them plant their flag on his palace. He watched them put him in a metal coffin. And he waited, because he knew something they didn't: the city was made of earth. The whole city. Every wall, every street, every building. And he was the most powerful earthbender alive. The Fire Nation was living inside his weapon and they didn't know it.

The moment will come. The eclipse always comes. The conditions for germination always arrive.

When I retake Omashu, I will not retake it with a lawsuit or a corporate acquisition or a hostile bid. I will retake it by building something so alive, so clearly the real thing, so obviously what Gumby always was — living, adaptive, transforming, free — that the corporate version will look like

what it is: a dead block wearing a green mask. The audience will see both and they will know. Clay knows clay. Life recognizes life.

And when they look at what I built — the book, the technology, the platform, the community, the living architecture that designs by describing conditions instead of commanding coordinates — they will see what Art saw when he first put his hands in clay. They will see what Gumby was always supposed to be.

Not a city manager. A doorway.

Not forever. The moment is coming. And when it does, I will move so fast that they will think I came out of nowhere. But you will know the truth: I was always here. Growing. Waiting. Listening.

Neutral jing.